

Photographs by SMAILESH RAVAL



charges of financial misappropriation and call him a pro-industrialist chief minister, Modi is quick to remind them of instances of corruption in previous regimes.

Modi's wear-them-down strategy is creating a sympathy wave in his favour which may decimate his rivals in the polls and eventually turn the tide in his favour. As political analyst Arvind Bosamia says, "Modi's opponents might feel confident but this feeling

MASS APPEAL: (Left) After seven years in power, the Modi magic endures; (below) BJP leaders at a rally

"Modi is the right person to be at the helm. He knows how to rule. Give him five more years and he will do wonders for Gujarat." The effect of the Koli strategy against Modi is also showing limited success. On the other hand if the anti-Patel rhetoric is taken beyond a point, it could result in non-Patels making a beeline for him.

Modi is also making an effort to bridge the caste gap using the Ram Sethu issue. In his quest to carve out the image of a developmental icon, many had thought Modi would underplay it. But to the surprise of many, he



"The Vande Gujarat mantra will take the state to new heights."

NARENDRA MODI, CHIEF MINISTER

people see the difference between his and the previous governments. As a minister in his Cabinet put it: "He wants them (Congress and rebel party members) to exhaust their quota of charges and abuses."

While his rivals call him arrogant, the impression he is trying to create is that of a He-man, someone who helped Gujarat become a revenue surplus state after a gap of 15 years. Hitting out at his opponents, he says, "The Sultanate of Delhi (Congress-led UPA Government) is trying to put hurdles in Gujarat's development. But friends, I have decided to defeat the anti-Gujarat forces, come what may." When they go further and hurl

could be misplaced because voters seem to have booked him in advance for the next electoral show." But there is another school of thought. Says a BJP leader: "If the arrogant image of Modi which his rivals are trying to portray influences the voters, then the results might be different. But that does not seem to be the case."

BJP rebels and the Congress are also trying to play the caste card against Modi by portraying him as anti-Patel and his Government as anti-Koli—another numerically strong caste in the state. But indications are that only a small faction of Patels in Saurashtra see him as anti-Patel. Bholabhai Patel, a farmer of village Jhulasan says,

is going hammer and tongs on the Ram Sethu to terrific response. He has chosen the issue to launch savage attacks on both—Sonia Gandhi and the Congress. "How would Soniabehn know the importance of Ram. After all, Ram was not born in Italy. While the Vanar Sena was constructing the bridge, Ravana must be secretly wishing for its destruction. Now, Congress seems to be implementing Ravana's unfinished agenda," he said at a public gathering in Saurashtra.

What appeals to the masses is his direct approach and smooth talk. Clearly, Modi, the He-man is here. Whether he is for real or of the celluloid variety, the verdict will soon be out. ■